

DIGITALAIKART

PREMIUM EXAM SERIES

NOVEMBER 29, 2026

THE CAT 2026 FINAL COUNTDOWN PLAYBOOK

Your complete 74-day system for the last stretch -
from today to the IIM entrance

74

DAYS TO THE EXAM

68

QUESTIONS, 3 SECTIONS

2.58 LAKH

COMPETITORS IN 2025

Every exam fact verified against the official IIM press release,
the CAT 2026 information bulletin and the official CAT 2025 media release.
September 2026 edition.

DIGITAL EDITION

CONTENTS

1	The Exam, Verified	Everything officially confirmed about CAT 2026 - dates, pattern, marking, slots
2	The Honest Diagnosis	Find your true starting point in one weekend, not one month
3	The 74-Day Master Plan	Three phases, one weekly rhythm, seven non-negotiables
4	The VARC Playbook	A reading system and a verbal toolkit built for 24 questions in 40 minutes
5	The DILR Playbook	Set selection, the two-set rule, and notation that never fails under pressure
6	The QA Playbook	Arithmetic first: the 74-day topic order that follows the actual paper
7	The Mock System	How many mocks, which ones, and the 3:1 analysis rule that turns scores around
8	The Week-by-Week Calendar	Ten and a half weeks, planned to the day
9	Working Professional and Final-Year Tracks	The same system, compressed to real life
10	The Last 14 Days	The taper protocol, day by day, up to November 28
11	Exam-Day Protocol	Slot timings, documents, and in-exam decision rules
12	After the Exam	Results, normalization, XAT 2027 on January 3, and the road to a B-school
13	FAQ and Official Resources	Straight answers, and every official link you need
A	The One-Page Exam-Day Rule Card	Print it, fold it, read it in the queue on November 29
B	The Math Quick-Reference Sheet	Arithmetic, algebra and geometry facts for the final fortnight

A note before you start

This playbook is built on facts, not motivation. Every number about the exam - dates, question counts, marking, fees, attendance - comes from the official IIM press releases and the official CAT 2025 media release, cross-checked in September 2026. Where something is an estimate from coaching institutes, we say so plainly. Your job for the next 74 days is not to feel inspired. It is to show up and execute a system.

CHAPTER 1

The Exam, Verified

Before strategy, the facts. Everything in this chapter is confirmed by the official CAT 2026 press release and information bulletin. Nothing here is guesswork, and you should not have to re-verify it - spend that time on arithmetic instead.

CAT 2026 is conducted by IIM Indore, and the exam is on **Sunday, November 29, 2026**, in three sessions across roughly 170 cities in India. You get 120 minutes for three sections - Verbal Ability and Reading Comprehension (VARC), Data Interpretation and Logical Reasoning (DILR), and Quantitative Ability (QA) - with exactly 40 minutes locked per section. You cannot switch sections. PwD candidates get 160 minutes total, with 53 minutes 20 seconds per section.

The official timeline

Event	Date	What it means for you
Registration window	Aug 3 - Sep 22, 2026 (5 pm)	Closed. If you missed it, CAT 2026 is gone - see Chapter 12 for XAT 2027.
Admit card download	Nov 4 - Nov 29, 2026	Download early; your slot and city are printed on it.
Exam day	Sun, Nov 29, 2026	Three sessions: 8:30-10:30 am, 12:30-2:30 pm, 4:30-6:30 pm.
Result	Expected first week of Jan 2027	Scores stay valid for the 2027 admission season.

The registration deadline was extended once, from September 15 to September 22, with the IIMs stating clearly it would not be extended again. If you registered, you are in. The fee was Rs. 2,700 (General, EWS and NC-OBC) or Rs. 1,350 (SC, ST and PwBD) - already paid, already done. After the window closed, a short edit window allowed changes only to photograph, signature and test-city preferences. Nothing else in your form can change now.

The pattern, based on the most recent real paper

The IIMs announce the structure (sections, 40-minute locks, 120-minute total) but not the exact question count in advance. The most recent real evidence is CAT 2025, conducted on November 30, 2025, whose official media release confirmed 68 questions: 24 in VARC, 22 in DILR and 22 in QA. Coaching analyses of all three 2025 slots found this mix:

Section	Questions	MCQ	Type-in-answer (TITA)	Time
VARC	24	20	4	40 min
DILR	22	11	11	40 min
QA	22	14	8	40 min
Total	68	45	23	120 min

Marking: +3 for a correct answer, -1 for a wrong MCQ, zero for a question left blank. TITA questions carry no negative marking - you type the answer instead of picking options, so a wrong typed answer costs you nothing. That asymmetry matters everywhere in this book.

Two rules that should shape your whole preparation

- **The section lock.** You cannot return to a finished section or jump ahead. A section that collapses in the hall is a section that stays collapsed. Every mock you take must respect the 40-minute lock, always.
- **Slot normalization.** Three sessions mean three different papers, and the IIMs scale scores across slots. You cannot control your slot; you can only control leaving attempts on the table. Never walk out of a section early just because it felt hard.

The size of the field - and why that is good news

In CAT 2025, about 2.95 lakh candidates registered and roughly 2.58 lakh actually appeared - an 86 percent attendance rate, as per the official media release. That means the 99th percentile is roughly the top 2,580 candidates, and the 95th percentile is roughly the top 12,900. Now the part most aspirants never internalize: a large share of the marks lost in a typical paper are lost not to hard questions but to panic, poor selection and avoidable negative marking - and all three are trainable, starting today. You do not need to beat 2.58 lakh people on talent. You need to beat them on process.

What percentile bands typically correspond to

Percentile needs change with the institution and category, and cutoffs move every year - so treat this as orientation, not gospel: the top IIMs' flagship programmes sit in the highest bands for general-category seats, the newer IIMs and strong university departments fill the middle bands, and hundreds of respected MBA programmes admit well below the mid-90s. With roughly 2.58 lakh candidates, every 5 percentile points is about 12,900 people - which is also why late, honest gains matter: moving from the 80th to the 90th percentile vaults you past more than 25,000 competitors, many of whom will be doing exactly what this book tells you not to do in November.

Why the pattern's stability is your biggest advantage

CAT's structure has been remarkably stable: 68 questions in the 2024 and 2025 editions, the same three sections, the same 40-minute locks, the same +3/-1 marking. The official press release for 2026 confirms the three sections and timings, and a format-familiarity mock is published on the official website. Stability is why this playbook can promise systems rather than vague advice: the exam you will write on November 29 is, structurally, the exam whose papers you can practise today.

Bottom line

68 questions, 204 marks, three locked 40-minute sections, November 29. Your preparation from here is not about learning more - it is about executing better on a known structure. The rest of this book is the execution.

CHAPTER 2

The Honest Diagnosis

Most of the last 74 days are wasted by people practising what they are already good at. One honest weekend of diagnosis fixes that. This chapter gives you the protocol.

Set aside one full weekend day. You will take one real paper under real conditions, mark it honestly, and face the number. Not the number you tell your friends - the real one.

The diagnostic protocol

- 1 Pick one recent official CAT paper (previous-year papers from 2017 to 2025 are available through the official CAT website, iimcat.ac.in). Choose a 2024 or 2025 paper for the most current pattern.
- 2 Sit it in one uninterrupted 120-minute block, respecting the 40-minute section locks. Phone in another room. Rough paper only - no calculator for the diagnostic.
- 3 Score it strictly: +3 correct, -1 wrong MCQ, 0 blank, no marks for wrong TITA.
- 4 Fill the error log (Chapter 7) for every question you got wrong or skipped. Do not skip this step - the log is the diagnosis.

Read your score in three layers

A raw score alone tells you little. Split it into attempts, accuracy and selection, because each failure has a different cure:

What you see	What it usually means	The fix (chapter)
Plenty of attempts, low accuracy	Concept gaps or rushing; negative marking is eating you alive	QA/VARC accuracy drills (Ch 4, 6)
Few attempts, high accuracy	Over-caution; you are leaving 10-15 minutes unused per section	Selection and pacing system (Ch 7)
One section far behind the others	A structural weakness, not a general one	That section's playbook (Ch 4-6)
Good at home, collapses in mocks	A pressure and stamina problem, not a knowledge problem	Mock system + taper (Ch 7, 10)

Know your profile

Fifteen years of CAT-coaching folklore sorts late-stage aspirants into four profiles. Find yourself, and take the prescribed first move this week:

Profile	The signals	First move this week
The Starter	Began prep recently; syllabus half-touched; no mock taken	Take the diagnostic, then build the plan around QA arithmetic + daily RC only
The Stalled	Months of prep, scores flat for 4-6 weeks, motivation dipping	Stop new topics; 10 days of error-log-driven repair, then re-mock
The Mock-Anxious	Strong concepts, mock scores swing wildly, overthinks in the hall	Fixed in-exam rules (Ch 11) rehearsed in every mock; mock count up, stakes down
The Time-Poor	Job or final-year classes; 2 hours a day if lucky	The compressed track (Ch 9); protect analysis time over question volume

A worked example of reading the number

Here is a realistic diagnostic result, read the way you should read yours - not as a verdict but as a parts list:

Section	Attempts	Correct	Accuracy	Reading
VARC	19	11	58%	Attempts fine; accuracy low - trap options are winning. Needs the option-elimination discipline of Ch 4
DILR	6	5	83%	Only 6 of 22 attempted - selection fear, not skill. The scan system of Ch 5 is the entire fix
QA	12	7	58%	Arithmetic-heavy attempts but algebra errors dominate the log - a two-topic repair list, not a syllabus problem

This candidate's instinct will be 'I am weak at maths.' The honest read is narrower: a two-topic repair list (algebra accuracy), a habit fix (RC traps) and a courage fix (DILR selection). Three concrete projects - each with a chapter of this book attached - is what a diagnosis looks like when it is done properly.

Set the target that matches the calendar

Honest calibration: the next 74 days reward focused, system-driven work with real percentile movement - more for some profiles, less for others - but the size of that movement gets decided by your mock trend in October, not by promises made to you in September. Do not chase a number a coaching billboard gave you: set your target 15 percentile points above your diagnostic, and let the trend tell you when to raise it.

The rule for the next 74 days

You get exactly one data-gathering weekend. After Sunday, you are no longer allowed to say 'I don't know where I stand.' You will know - and every plan in this book starts from that number.

CHAPTER 3

The 74-Day Master Plan

Seventy-four days is not one long grind - it is three short campaigns. Each phase has one job. Mixing the jobs is why people plateau.

PHASE 1

Sep 17 - Oct 11: Repair

PHASE 2

Oct 12 - Nov 15: Intensify

PHASE 3

Nov 16 - Nov 29: Taper

Phase 1 - Repair (Sep 17 to Oct 11)

Job: close concept gaps and install daily habits. You take your first mock in week one (you already took the diagnostic), then roughly one full mock a week while repairing topics the mocks expose. Daily shape: 2-3 focused hours - one QA topic block (arithmetic first, per Chapter 6), one reading block (Chapter 4's RC system), and two DILR sets with full review. Nothing glamorous. If a topic from your error log stays broken after two repair attempts, mark it a skip-topic and stop paying it attention - 74 days from now you will not need every topic; you will need the ones you own cold.

Phase 2 - Intensify (Oct 12 to Nov 15)

Job: convert knowledge into a repeatable 120-minute performance. Mocks rise to two a week; analysis time now outranks practice volume (the 3:1 rule, Chapter 7). This is also the window for sectional tests - one weak section, drilled every day. All syllabus coverage finishes by November 1, because the last two weeks of Phase 2 belong to refinement, not new material. Expect the ugly mid-phase dip: around mock 6-8 your scores may drop as you abandon old habits. Hold the system; the dip is the old strategy leaving.

Phase 3 - Taper (Nov 16 to Nov 29)

Job: arrive fresh, sharp and boring. No new topics after November 15 - ever, for anyone. One light mock in the taper's first week (around Nov 22, your last full mock), then sectional revision from your error log only. Sleep resets to your exam slot. Chapter 10 gives you the day-by-day. Most aspirants arrive on exam day over-revised and under-slept; the taper exists to invert that.

The weekly rhythm (works in every phase)

Day	Weekday template (2-3 hrs)	What changes
Mon	QA topic block + error-log review	Phase 2: add one sectional
Tue	RC system block (2 passages) + VA drill	Same in all phases
Wed	DILR: 3 timed sets + full review	Phase 2: 2 sets + 1 sectional
Thu	QA practice set + redo log items	Redo rule: 7 days after first fail
Fri	Light day: 30 min reading + formula sheet	Protects the weekend long block
Sat	FULL MOCK (same slot as exam once known) + first-pass analysis	The anchor of the week
Sun	Deep mock analysis (2-3 hrs) + weakest-section drill	Never skip; this is where score lives

The daily block, phase by phase

Phase	Weekday (2-3 hrs)	Weekend (5-6 hrs)
1 - Repair	QA repair block 60-75 min; RC passage 25 min; 2 DILR sets 40 min; log 10 min	Full mock (one per week) + same-day first-pass analysis; deep analysis Sunday
2 - Intensify	Alternating: weakest-section sectional + error-log redos; QA mixed sets; VA drill	Two mocks; full 3:1 analysis each; one fresh-timed DILR block; trend review
3 - Taper	One confidence block per day (solved-pile reps); formula sheets; 30-min reading	Nov 22 final mock; then sectionals, then nothing timed after Nov 26

Seven non-negotiables

- 1 Read 30 minutes daily - an editorial or long-form essay, printed or on screen. Not reels, not summaries. This is VARC's compound interest.
- 2 Every wrong or skipped question enters the error log the same day. No exceptions; the log is the whole system's memory.
- 3 Sleep 7+ hours. All-nighters before November 29 cost you marks, they do not earn them.
- 4 One full mock every week at minimum, always 120 timed minutes, always section-locked.
- 5 Redo every error-log item after 7 days. A topic is fixed when you solve it cold twice, not once.
- 6 No new prep material after October 15. New books in the last six weeks are procrastination in disguise.
- 7 One full rest evening a week. A system you cannot sustain for 74 days is a system you do not have.

CHAPTER 4

The VARC Playbook

VARC is 24 questions in 40 minutes - 16 from four reading passages, 8 from verbal puzzles. It is the section where process beats vocabulary, every single time.

What the section actually contains

In CAT 2025, every slot had the same shape: four RC passages of four questions each, then eight verbal-ability questions - two summary, two paragraph-completion, two odd-sentence-out and two para-jumbles (the jumbles returned in 2025 after a gap). Of the 24 questions, 20 were MCQs and 4 were TITA (typically the odd-one-out and jumbles). Difficulty was rated moderate across slots; the essays were dense but the questions centred on the author's core ideas.

The 40-minute budget

Block	Time	Notes
RC passages (4 x 4 questions)	30-32 min	7-8 minutes a passage; if a passage eats 10, the next one gets 6 - decide consciously
VA questions (8)	8-10 min	Mostly quicker; para-jumbles are TITA - no negative, always attempt

The RC system: read once, map as you go

The fatal VARC habit is re-reading. Fix it structurally: read the passage once, actively, at your natural pace - and while reading, keep a tiny mental map of what each paragraph does (the claim, the counter-example, the concession, the conclusion). CAT's RC questions rarely ask for recalled detail; they ask what the author is doing. When you reach the questions, you should be able to locate the relevant paragraph from your map in seconds, not by re-scanning the whole passage.

- Main-idea and primary-purpose questions: the answer must cover the whole passage, not one paragraph it likes.
- Inference questions: the correct option is the cautious one. Extreme words (only, never, must, all) are usually the trap.
- Specific-detail questions: go to the mapped paragraph first; the options love to distort one verb or one number.
- Application tone questions: ask what the author would agree with, in the author's own register - not what is true in the real world.

The VA toolkit, question by question

Type	Format	Tactic
Summary	MCQ	Find the option that keeps the logic chain and drops the examples; wrong options over-add or under-cover
Paragraph completion	MCQ	The missing sentence must follow from the last line and set up the next; watch pronoun and connector signals
Odd sentence out	TITA	Three sentences share one story; find the one on a different mission, not merely the one you dislike
Para-jumbles	TITA	No negative marking - always attempt. Chain pronouns and connectors (however, this, those) to link, then order

What the 2025 passages actually asked about

Institute analyses of the CAT 2025 slots reported RC passages on the history of alienists and diagnosing mental disorders, income inequality and economic growth, objections to electronic music, and complex systems and tail events - classic CAT territory: humanities, economics, science and philosophy, dense but readable. Two practical implications: first, your daily reading should range across these genres, not just business news; second, dense does not mean hard - in 2025 the questions largely centred on the passages' central ideas, which is exactly what the map-while-reading system trains.

The four trap options, by name

- **The Extremist** - takes the author's qualified claim and hardens it (some becomes all, may becomes must). On inference questions this trap wins more marks from good readers than any other.
- **The True-but-Irrelevant** - factually correct in the real world, but never said or implied in the passage. Your loyalty is to the text, not to truth.
- **The Half-Coverer** - accurate about one paragraph but wrong as a summary of the whole passage; the classic main-idea trap.
- **The Over-Adder** - adds a comparison, cause or consequence the author never asserted. Watch for it especially in summary questions.

The VARC practice progression, 74 days

Block	Daily dose	The discipline
Sep 17 - Oct 11	1 passage + 3 VA questions	Untimed accuracy first: 70%+ before speed
Oct 12 - Nov 1	2 passages + 5 VA questions	Timed: 8 minutes a passage; traps named and logged
Nov 2 - Nov 22	One 24-question sectional, 3x a week	Full 40-minute sections; VA order decided (jumbles first or last, fixed forever)
Nov 23 - 29	1 light passage daily	Confidence reps only

The accuracy math that should scare you straight

With +3 and -1, accuracy dominates volume. Ten RC attempts at 80 percent accuracy score $10 \times (8 \times 3 - 2 \times 1) = 22$. Twelve attempts at 55 percent score $12 \times (6.6 \times 3 - 5.4 \times 1) = 17.6$ - and that assumes the extra two attempts were not wild guesses. In VARC, the aspirant who reads patiently and attempts 18-20 with 80 percent accuracy beats the one who races through 24 at 60 percent. Every time. Your drill target: 70-80 percent accuracy on RC at 7-8 minutes a passage.

The daily 30 minutes that quietly builds the score

Read one serious editorial or essay every day - national dailies' opinion pages, long-form magazine features, book excerpts. After each, write one sentence: what was the author's point, and what would they never say? That one sentence is your inference-muscle. Candidates who do this for 74 straight days routinely describe VARC going from their weakest section to their stabilizer. It is the cheapest score in the entire exam.

If VARC is your weak section

Do not touch vocabulary lists now. All your gains come from the RC system (read once, map, 70%+ accuracy) and from TITA verbal questions where guessing is free. Two passages a day, every day, until November 22.

CHAPTER 5

The DILR Playbook

DILR was the consensus toughest section of CAT 2025. It is also the most learnable in 74 days - because its difficulty is process, not knowledge.

What the section actually contains

CAT 2025's DILR ran 22 questions in five sets - two sets of 5 questions and three sets of 4 - split almost evenly between MCQ (11) and TITA (11). Sets covered arrangements, groupings, schedules and data-heavy interpretation (bar charts, scatter plots, weighted indices). Across coaching analyses, most candidates could finish only about two sets properly - and that was enough for a strong sectional score.

The selection scan - the highest-value 4 minutes of the section

- 1 Minutes 0-4: read every set's stimulus quickly. Do not solve. Classify each: A = structure I have drilled and data I can hold; B = familiar type but heavy data; C = alien structure or story I cannot parse.
- 2 Start with an A set. Crack it fully, bank the questions, then the next A.
- 3 The 8-minute rule: if a set has not broken open after 8 focused minutes, walk away - even mid-insight. Sunk cost is how DILR destroys sections.
- 4 Leftover time goes to B sets' easy standalone questions, and TITA attempts (no negative marking).

The 2025 sets, as reported by institute analyses

Slot-level analyses of CAT 2025 reported these representative sets: performance ratings of six employees; import-export data of five countries; a circular arrangement of four persons and seven chairs; five persons tapping yes/no; train movement from station A to E; a pollution index requiring weighted averages; authors and books shown in paired bar graphs; a scatter-plot index across three years; a ranking puzzle of six balls into four holes; and a musicians scheduling puzzle. Study that list and notice what is absent: no exotic formats. The skill ceiling is standard structures executed accurately under pressure - which is precisely what 74 days of drilling buys.

The two-set rule

In a paper like 2025's, two clean sets plus two or three picked-off singles was a strong performance - coaching commentary pegged roughly 10 good attempts in DILR as a competitive showing. Say it aloud: you do not need five sets. You need two sets done at 100 percent accuracy plus disciplined picking. The aspirant who chases all five sets solves none well and panics in public.

Notation discipline - your only real DILR skill

Under pressure, sloppy notation is what actually fails. Build one standard kit and use it in every practice set from today:

- People/objects in a vertical column; slots across. Fill confirmed cells with capital letters, possibilities in pencil-light notation you define once (e.g., 'x' = impossible, '?' = open).
- One inequality or comparison per line, numbered, so a later question can cite your own line 3 as a fact.
- For DI sets: before touching questions, compute the obvious derived numbers (totals, ranks, maxima) once, in the margin, with labels. Most questions are then look-ups.
- Redraw, never overwrite. When new information lands, a fresh clean grid beats an archaeology dig through crossed-out cells.

The 74-day set menu

Weeks	Daily dose	Target types
Sep 17 - Oct 11	2 sets, untimed then timed	Arrangements (linear/circular), groupings, simple DI tables
Oct 12 - Nov 1	2-3 timed sets + 1 sectional/week	Add scheduling, tournaments, matrix puzzles, bar/scatter DI
Nov 2 - Nov 22	3 timed sets mixed difficulty	Full 22-question sectionals twice a week; selection scan rehearsed every time
Nov 23 - 29	1 light set daily	Confidence reps only from the error log's solved pile

The redo rule, doubled

Every DILR set you fail goes into the log and gets a full re-solve after 7 days - and, uniquely in DILR, a re-solve after 21 days too. Sets recur structurally: a trains-and-stations set from a 2024 paper teaches the muscles a delivery-routes set will test in yours. The candidates who score in DILR's top band are rarely smarter; they have simply seen more structures.

If DILR is your weak section

Your entire program is: the selection scan, the 8-minute rule, and 2 sets a day with full review. Do not buy more DILR books. The 2017-2025 official papers are more than enough sets to master selection.

CHAPTER 6

The QA Playbook

In CAT 2025, arithmetic alone was roughly a third of QA - and the easiest marks in the paper. Your topic order for 74 days follows the actual marks, not the textbook's.

What the section actually contained

QA in CAT 2025 carried 22 questions (14 MCQ, 8 TITA) and was rated medium overall, with Slot 3 harder. Coaching breakdowns of all slots put arithmetic at 7-8 questions - the largest single block - followed by algebra (4-5), modern math (3-4), geometry (3) and number systems (2-4). Commentary from major institutes consistently noted that 11-12 solid, accurate attempts could be decisive - QA rewards precision and selection more than coverage.

The 74-day topic order

Priority	Block	Core topics	Why this order
1	Arithmetic	Percentages, ratios, averages, mixtures, profit-loss, time-work, speed-distance	Biggest block, fastest to repair, feeds DI too
2	Algebra	Linear/quadratic equations, inequalities, logarithms, surds-indices, progressions	Second-biggest block; formula-light if concepts are clear
3	Geometry	Triangles, circles, basic coordinate geometry	3 questions a paper; standard results pay fast
4	Modern math	Permutations-combinations, probability, set theory	3-4 questions; do the standard models only
5	Numbers	Factors, divisibility, remainders basics	Small payoff per hour at this stage - cap the time

If your diagnostic says you already own a block, compress it: one revision day, then maintain with 5 mixed questions a week. The calendar (Chapter 8) assumes arithmetic needs the most repair because that is true for most late-stage aspirants.

The repair loop for any topic

- 1 Relearn the concept in 30 minutes - from whichever single source you already own. One source. Comparing three teachers is how 74 days disappear.
- 2 Solve 15-20 questions on it, from easy up to CAT-2025 level. Untimed first pass.
- 3 Every miss goes to the error log with the cause: concept, calculation slip, misread, or abandoned too early.
- 4 Redo the misses after 7 days, cold. Fixed twice = done. Still failing = skip-topic (you have others).

Speed comes from choices, not from tricks

Vedic-math shortcuts are mostly theatre at this stage. What actually saves minutes in the hall:

- First 15 seconds of every question: is this arithmetic I can do cleanly, or algebra I should set up once? Setting up twice is where minutes die.
- Scan the options before solving fully - often only one option is even the right order of magnitude, or two die on parity/units instantly.
- Approximate deliberately when options are far apart; compute exactly only when they cluster.

- The 2-minute rule: no question earns more than 2 unrewarded minutes before you mark-and-move (MCQs: guess only if you can eliminate two options; TITA: always type your best value - no negative marking).

What actually appeared in QA 2025

Institute slot reports for CAT 2025 listed questions on logarithms, percentages, time-speed-distance, time and work, triangles, inequalities, surds, number systems, profit and loss on marked price, mixtures and alligations, permutations-combinations, linear and quadratic equations, and coordinate geometry - with commentary noting that arithmetic questions were numerous but often required multi-step computation. Translation for your planning: the arithmetic block's topics are not just frequent, they are exactly the topics where careless-process errors cost marks. Drill them for accuracy, not just speed.

The topic self-audit (do this once, tonight)

Topic	Rate yourself (1-5)	Where it lands
Percentages, ratios, averages		Below 3: repair this week - feeds most other topics
Profit-loss, mixtures		Below 3: repair in Phase 1
Time-work, speed-distance		Below 3: repair in Phase 1; formula-light, model-heavy
Equations, inequalities, logs		Below 3: first fortnight of October
Triangles, circles		Below 3: mid-October; standard results suffice
P&C, probability, sets		Below 3: late October; cap at 4 practice hours if stubborn
Number systems		Below 3: maintenance mode - 5 questions/week, nothing more

Anything rated 4-5 gets maintenance only: five mixed questions a week to stay warm. The calendar in Chapter 8 assumes the 2s and 3s get the repair loop. Print this table, fill it in, and pin it above your desk - it is your personal Phase 1.

The TITA edge in QA

Eight of 22 QA questions in 2025 were TITA - type-in-answer, no options, and crucially no negative marking. That changes behaviour: a TITA question you can shrink to a narrow estimate is still worth typing. Build the habit of attempting every TITA you can even partially reason, and never leaving one blank in the last minute. Free non-negative swings are the cheapest marks in CAT.

If QA is your weak section

Arithmetic + your log, nothing else, until October 11. The arithmetic block alone historically carries 7-8 questions - mastering it is worth more than touching every topic superficially.

CHAPTER 7

The Mock System

Mocks do not improve scores. Mock analysis does. The mock is the camera; the analysis is the training. Most aspirants only ever take photos.

How many mocks, and which ones

In 74 days, the right dose is 12-15 full mocks plus 10-12 sectional tests - roughly one full mock a week through Phase 1 and early Phase 2, then two a week from mid-October. More than that and analysis collapses into score-watching, which is entertainment. For sources:

- **The official CAT mock** on iimcat.ac.in - take it once in Phase 1 to learn the real interface (timer, navigation, the on-screen calculator) and once again in the final week. It is the only source with zero style drift.
- **Official previous-year papers, 2017-2025** - your gold standard for difficulty and structure. At least six of your 15 mocks should be real papers, recent years first.
- **One reputable mock series** for volume and current-season timing - any established provider, one series only, chosen now and never switched again.

The 3:1 rule

For every 120-minute mock, schedule at least 180 minutes of analysis spread over the next two days. The analysis is a fixed ritual, not a mood:

- 1 Day-of (60 min, after a break): re-solve every question you got wrong or skipped - with the answer hidden, not stared at. Most 'revelations' happen only when you genuinely retry.
- 2 Same evening (30 min): classify every miss into the taxonomy - concept gap, calculation slip, misread, time pressure, wrong selection, or panic. Different causes, different cures.
- 3 Next day (60 min): update the error log, pick the three changes you will enforce in the next mock (for example: scan all DILR sets first 4 minutes; attempt all TITA), and write them at the top of the next mock's rough sheet.
- 4 Weekly (30 min, Sunday): track attempts, accuracy and time-per-section in a simple sheet; the trend, not any single score, decides whether strategy holds or changes.

The error log - the single highest-leverage artifact of your 74 days

Field	What to write	Example
Question ref	Paper, section, Q number	CAT 2024 Slot 2, QA, Q14
Topic	Narrow, not broad	Time and work - pipes
Error type	One of: concept / calculation / misread / selection / time	Calculation slip under time
The fix	One sentence, actionable	Write units next to every line; re-check sign flips
Redo dates	+7 days, (+21 for DILR/concept)	Oct 3; Oct 17

Paper notebook or spreadsheet both work; the discipline matters, the medium does not. By mid-November your log is effectively your personal textbook - the only revision material that is 100 percent about you.

The 13-mock calendar

Mock	When	Type	The question it answers
1	Week 1 (Sep 19-20)	Recent official paper	Where do I actually stand?
2	Oct 3-4	Official paper	Did Phase 1 repair move the weakest topic?
3	Oct 10-11	Mock series	Is my Phase 1 strategy sheet holding?
4-5	Oct 17-18	One official + one series	Can I hold the 2-set rule for two weeks straight?
6-7	Oct 24-25	Series	Where does the mid-plan dip sit? (Expect it; log it)
8-9	Oct 31 - Nov 1	Series	Is full syllabus coverage complete and calm?
10-11	Nov 7-8	Official papers, at slot time	Does my stamina match my real slot?
12-13	Nov 14-15	Series, at slot time	Is the frozen strategy repeatable twice in a row?
Final	Nov 22	Best series mock, full protocol	Dress rehearsal - then never again

Everything between these anchors is sectional work and repair. If you start late or fall behind, drop mocks from the middle of the table - never the Week 1 diagnostic, never the Nov 7-8 slot-time pair, never the Nov 22 final.

Reading mock scores without fooling yourself

- Single-mock swings are noise. Judge only 3-mock moving averages.
- A score drop right after a strategy change (attempts up, accuracy down) is often the valley before the gain - give a deliberate change two mocks before judging.
- Never change more than one rule per mock. Otherwise you cannot attribute the movement to anything.
- Once your admit card arrives (Nov 4), take every mock at your actual slot time. Stamina is time-of-day specific.

The mock-anxious profile's special assignment

For six straight mocks, your only goal is the process checklist - not the score. Scan done? 8-minute rule held? All TITA attempted? Tick the boxes, ignore the number. Score follows process; process first, always.

CHAPTER 8

The Week-by-Week Calendar

The whole plan on a page you can screenshot. Each week lists its single job, its focus blocks, and its milestone. If you fall behind, you drop items from the bottom of the list - never the mock.

Week 1 - Sep 17 to 23: Diagnosis

Job: know your number. Take the diagnostic (Ch 2) and your first full mock. Start the error log on day one. Daily: one QA arithmetic topic (percentages, ratios), one RC passage, two easy DILR sets. Milestone: a written percentile baseline and your three weakest topics.

Week 2 - Sep 24 to 30: Systems install

Job: make the daily rhythm automatic. Arithmetic continues (averages, mixtures, profit-loss), the RC system (read once, map) becomes habit, DILR notation kit gets standardised. Milestone: 7 consecutive days hitting every non-negotiable.

Week 3 - Oct 1 to 7: Arithmetic done, algebra begins

Job: finish time-work and speed-distance; open algebra with equations and inequalities. Mock 2 this weekend - full analysis per the 3:1 ritual. Milestone: arithmetic block at 70%+ accuracy in sectional drills.

Week 4 - Oct 8 to 11: Phase 1 close (short week)

Job: Phase 1 review. Reread your entire error log; anything failing its +7-day redo gets one more repair session or becomes a skip-topic. Light mock 3 at week's end. Milestone: a one-page strategy sheet - your attempt targets per section.

Week 5 - Oct 12 to 18: Intensify

Job: mocks now 2x weekly. Geometry block runs alongside algebra finish (logs, surds, progressions). VARC: VA types drilled daily - summary and paragraph-completion are quick wins. Milestone: mock 4 and 5 analysed; first 3-mock trend read.

Week 6 - Oct 19 to 25: Volume and patterns

Job: modern math (permutations, probability, set theory) plus numbers basics. DILR moves to mixed timed sets. Mocks 6 and 7. Expect the dip; hold the system. Milestone: full syllabus touched once.

Week 7 - Oct 26 to Nov 1: Coverage complete

Job: last new-topic day is Nov 1. From here, only consolidation. Error-log redo marathon: everything marked +21 days comes back now. Mocks 8 and 9. Milestone: syllabus coverage 100 percent - never to be reopened.

Week 8 - Nov 2 to 8: Slot reality

Job: admit card lands Nov 4 - know your slot and city. From now, every mock at your real slot time. Sectional tests begin in your weakest section, daily if needed. Mocks 10 and 11. Milestone: attempts strategy frozen - question counts per section you will not exceed even on a good day.

Week 9 - Nov 9 to 15: Phase 2 close

Job: mocks 12 and 13 (the last heavy ones), then a written exam-strategy sheet: scan routines, minute budgets, abandon rules, TITA always. Milestone: strategy sheet printed and stuck where you study.

Week 10 - Nov 16 to 22: Taper begins

Job: volume drops a third. Final full mock on Nov 22 - your dress rehearsal, at your slot time, full protocol. Revision is error-log-only. Sleep schedule starts shifting to slot time. Milestone: the Nov 22 mock, treated as the real thing.

Week 11 - Nov 23 to 29: The final week

Follow Chapter 10's day-by-day. Nothing new. Confidence reps from the solved pile, logistics, sleep. Milestone: Sunday, November 29 - executed, not survived.

The one-rule recovery plan

Miss a day? Resume, do not compensate - double-sessions after missed days cause the next miss. Miss a week (illness, deadlines)? Cut from the bottom of the priority stack: numbers and modern math drills go first, then extra VARC VA volume. The mocks and the error-log redos are never cut. The plan bends; the anchor holds.

CHAPTER 9

Working Professional and Final-Year Tracks

The 74-day plan compressed for real lives. Same phases, same non-negotiables, honest arithmetic about hours.

The working professional (2 to 2.5 hours a weekday)

Slot	Time	Content
Early morning (or first work break)	45 min	RC passage + VA drill, or 2 DILR sets alternating days
Commute	20-30 min	The daily 30-minute reading habit (Ch 4) - the one block a commute is perfect for
Evening	75-90 min	QA topic block or error-log redos; Fridays: formula-sheet skim only
Saturday	3 hrs	Full mock at slot time + first-pass analysis
Sunday	3 hrs	Deep analysis + weakest-section sectional; then OFF until Monday evening

Two rules keep this version alive. First, analysis is sacred: if a brutal week forces cuts, cut practice volume, never mock analysis - the analysis is where working professionals gain, because their practice hours are already lean. Second, social media during the commute is the single biggest recoverable hour of your week; the reading habit pays VARC marks for the same minutes.

The final-year student

You have more hours but more chaos - classes, semester pressure, placement season colliding with November. The plan holds with two adjustments: front-load Phase 1 aggressively (you can run 4-5 hours on light class days; the working professional cannot), and place mocks where the academic calendar has gaps, not where the coaching marketing calendar says. If placement interviews land in November, take the week's mock on the alternate day and add one more rest evening - interview adrenaline and mock fatigue compound badly.

The placement-season collision, handled

Final-year students face a specific November problem: placement interviews and CAT's final fortnight overlap. The rule that saves both: through October, CAT wins the calendar's prime hours; from November 1, whichever event comes first on any given day wins that day, and the other gets maintenance only (a reading session or a log skim - 30 minutes, done guilt-free). A botched CAT cannot be fixed by a placement offer, and vice versa; the overlap is manageable precisely because neither needs heroics in its final two weeks - both need consistency. And interview season has one hidden gift: it forces you to articulate your story out loud, which is exactly the WAT-PI muscle Chapter 12 says you will need by February.

If life leaves you only 2 hours a day, period

- 1 45 minutes QA arithmetic + algebra only (the two biggest blocks).
- 2 30 minutes: one RC passage done with the full system + 2 VA questions.
- 3 30 minutes: two timed DILR sets with review.
- 4 15 minutes: error-log update and one redo item.
- 5 Weekly: one full mock + its analysis, Saturday and Sunday, protected like a family function.

That is a real plan, not a consolation prize - it covers the highest-yield blocks of all three sections. What it cannot survive is skipping step 5. The weekly mock is the only place the other six days' work gets integrated.

The honest trade-off

Compressed tracks typically target the 85-95 percentile band, not the 99th - that is arithmetic, not pessimism. If your target sits higher, something in your week has to give a real hour, not an imaginary one. Decide now, not in November.

CHAPTER 10

The Last 14 Days

From November 16 the only goals are freshness, sharpness and logistics. You cannot add marks in the final fortnight; you can only lose them - to fatigue, over-revision and new-topic anxiety.

The taper laws

- No new topics. Not one. If it is unfamiliar on Nov 16, it stays unfamiliar on Nov 29 - and that is fine; you are not writing 68/68.
- Volume drops by roughly a third. Confidence reps from the solved pile beat heroic new sets.
- Sleep migrates to your slot: slot-1 candidates (8:30 am) are in bed by 10 pm from Nov 20; slot-3 candidates (4:30 pm) protect the mid-afternoon nap option and normal nights.
- The last full mock is November 22. After that, sectionals only, and after November 26, nothing timed at all.

Day by day, Nov 20 to 29

Day	The plan
Fri Nov 20	Sectional: weakest section, timed. Light error-log skim. Slot-1 sleep shift begins.
Sat Nov 21	Sectional: other two sections, timed. 30-min reading. Early night.
Sun Nov 22	FINAL FULL MOCK at your slot time, full protocol - same wake-up, same food, same rough-paper discipline. First-pass analysis only; done by evening.
Mon Nov 23	Deep analysis of the final mock. Write the exam-day rule card (Ch 11). Nothing else.
Tue Nov 24	Error-log revision: QA formula sheet + the ten log items that cost you the most marks across the season.
Wed Nov 25	DILR: two favourite solved sets, re-solved clean. VARC: two passages. Logistics check (documents, route, alarm).
Thu Nov 26	Last timed sectionals (light, half-length acceptable). Print admit card copies (2), arrange the same photograph as uploaded, photo ID, reach-forbidden-items list.
Fri Nov 27	Gentle day: formula sheet, log skim, 30-min reading. No mock, no test, no new set. Pack the bag. Early dinner.
Sat Nov 28	Optional: 30 minutes of easy log items in the morning. Walk, eat familiar food, zero prep talk with anxious groups. Sleep at your shifted hour - alarm set, backup alarm set.
Sun Nov 29	Exam day. Follow Chapter 11 to the letter. Between waking and entering the hall: no last-minute formula lists.

The exam-bag checklist

- Admit card - two printed copies, checked against your uploaded photograph and signature.
- The same passport photographs as your registration upload (white background, taken within six months of it) - carry spares.
- One original photo ID from the admit card's accepted list - the physical card, not a photo of it.
- Water (if the centre's rules allow), familiar snacks for the wait outside; nothing labelled, nothing fancy.
- Printed copy of your rule card (Ch 11) - read it in the queue, not the formulas.

- Leave at home: phone, smartwatch, any digital device, notes, books. The queue discussion outside is not revision; it is noise.

What the last 14 days actually decide

Every mark you will earn on November 29 already exists in you. The fortnight's only questions are whether your stamina, sleep and nerves let those marks out - the same knowledge performs differently in a rested body than a frazzled one. This is why Chapter 3's taper phase forbids what your anxiety will demand: one more mock, one more book, one more 1 a.m. revision. The system already worked. Let it.

If panic arrives anyway

It will, somewhere around Nov 24. Protocol: open the error log, read page one - every item there is a question you can now solve that you could not in September. Seventy-four days of evidence beats one evening of fear. Then close the log and go to sleep.

CHAPTER 11

Exam-Day Protocol

November 29, decided by details you control. Three sessions run on the day: 8:30-10:30 am, 12:30-2:30 pm, and 4:30-6:30 pm - yours is printed on your admit card, downloadable from November 4.

Before you leave home

- Admit card printed (two copies), plus the same passport photograph you uploaded at registration - the registration guide requires the photo on exam day to match the uploaded one (not older than six months, white background). Carry spares.
- One original photo ID (the admit card lists accepted IDs). No digital-only versions.
- Leave every electronic item at home or with your escort - phones, smartwatches and even basic digital watches are barred at reporting.
- Plan arrival for the reporting time printed on your admit card, with travel buffer; centres run biometric verification and frisking, and queues build in the final hour.
- Eat familiar food. No experiment has ever improved an exam-day lunch.

The morning timeline (calibrate to your slot)

Slot	Wake	Leave home	In the centre
Slot 1 (8:30-10:30 am)	5.5-6 hrs before, so ~4:00 am is wrong - target 10 pm sleep, 5:30-6:00 am rise	To arrive by the admit card's reporting time with an hour of buffer	Verification queues eat time; you want to be early-list, not rushed-list
Slot 2 (12:30-2:30 pm)	Normal hours; a real breakfast, not a snack	Late morning, off-peak traffic	Eat something familiar an hour before reporting
Slot 3 (4:30-6:30 pm)	Normal hours; avoid the post-lunch crash with a walk	Early afternoon	The long wait is the risk: sit, hydrate, read nothing stressful

Reporting time is printed on your admit card and is earlier than you instinctively expect - biometric registration and frisking run for the whole cohort. Build the buffer before you need it; a calm extra 20 minutes outside the hall is worth more than one more formula.

Inside the paper: the minute-by-minute rules

- The on-screen timer is section-locked - 40 minutes each, VARC first, then DILR, then QA. The official mock on iimcat.ac.in shows this interface; you should have seen it twice before exam day.
- Section 1 (VARC): your RC system runs on rails now - read once, map, and answer from the map. Do not let a dense passage reset your pace.
- Section 2 (DILR): the 4-minute selection scan happens first, always, even if the first set looks inviting. Two clean sets beat five heroic half-sets.
- Section 3 (QA): first 90 seconds, scroll the whole section quietly. Your arithmetic block is in there - find it early and bank it before touching anything exotic.
- The 2-minute rule holds inside the hall. Mark-and-move on MCQs; always type best-effort on TITA (no negative marking).

Containment: when a section goes badly

It will happen to you in one section - it happens to almost everyone, including eventual 99-percentilers. The containment protocol:

- 1 Three slow breaths, feet flat, one swallow of water if permitted at your desk policy's discretion. Ten seconds, spent deliberately.
- 2 Recompute the target for the remaining time - not the original target. A bad DILR does not mean a bad CAT; it means DILR's remaining minutes get spent on singles and TITA.
- 3 Do not carry the bad section forward: the next section starts at 0-0 emotionally, whatever the timer says. The section lock that hurts you here also protects you - it is physically impossible for the previous section to follow you.

Between leaving the hall and going home

Three sessions run on the same day, which means paper discussion floods social media through the afternoon. If you are in a later slot, remember every analysis, answer key and 'confirmed leak' circulating mid-day is about a different paper than yours - slot papers differ and normalization exists precisely for this. Stay off the groups until your own session is done. Then stay off them anyway; the exam is written, the score is sealed, and the only thing discussion can still change is your sleep.

The rule card (write this on your rough sheet's first page on Nov 29)

Scan before solving. Two sets, done clean. Two minutes, then move. TITA: always answer. Read once, answer from the map. Breathe first, then decide. That is the whole game.

CHAPTER 12

After the Exam

CAT 2026 results are expected in the first week of January 2027, and your score stays valid through the 2027 admission season. Here is the map for what comes next - and the insurance policy you should hold regardless.

Results and normalization

Three sessions mean three papers of somewhat different difficulty. The IIMs therefore scale scores across slots before percentiles are computed - your raw 40-minute performance becomes a normalized sectional and overall score. Two consequences: your percentile is not a fixed function of your attempt count, and comparing raw scores across slots (or across Telegram groups) is meaningless. Judge your performance on your own execution against your strategy sheet - not on the rumour of someone else's raw score.

The insurance policy: XAT 2027, January 3

Registration for XAT 2027 - conducted for XLRI Jamshedpur and accepted by 250+ B-schools - runs until December 6, 2026, with the exam on Sunday, January 3, 2027, 2:00 to 5:00 pm. The fee is Rs. 2,300 (plus Rs. 200 per XLRI programme you apply to). Register even if you feel good about CAT, because:

- Your CAT preparation transfers almost entirely - the extra five weeks are pure polish on the same muscles.
- A second, earlier result removes the January dead-zone where anxiety does its worst work.
- It converts a single 120-minute performance into a portfolio - one bad Sunday no longer ends the season.

If the calls come: the WAT-PI runway

A CAT score is a door-opener, not an admission. IIM shortlists typically form in January-February, followed by written ability tests, group discussions and personal interviews through the season. Once your result lands, you have roughly four to six weeks before interviews - enough time to prepare your 'why MBA' story, your work-history narrative and current-affairs awareness, but only if you start the week the result arrives. Candidates who treat January as a holiday spend March explaining why they didn't.

The WAT-PI runway, week by week

When	What to do
Result week (early Jan)	Map which programmes your score realistically opens; note each one's shortlist window and process on one sheet
Week 1-2 after result	Draft your story: why MBA, why now, what your academic and work history actually proves. Write it, say it aloud, cut it to 90 seconds
Week 2-4	Current affairs: 20 minutes daily, one notebook; WAT practice = one essay every three days, timed, handwritten
Through the season	Mock interviews with anyone who will push back; record yourself; watch for filler words under pressure

If the score disappoints: the honest fork

Two roads, both legitimate. Road one: accept a B-school that matches your actual score - tier perceptions matter less in the long run than people insist, and the 2027 admission season still has live options. Road two: a retake with a full season - in which case your error log, kept intact, is worth more in the first month of the next attempt than any new coaching enrolment. What the fork does not permit is the third, unspoken road: drifting, re-litigating November 29 for months, preparing for nothing. Choose a road in the week the result arrives.

The quiet truth of the last 74 days

Whatever the percentile, the system you just ran - diagnosis, repair, disciplined mocks, honest analysis, taper - is the same one professionals use for every high-stakes performance for the rest of your life. The score is the receipt. The capability is the purchase.

CHAPTER 13

FAQ and Official Resources

Short answers to the questions this playbook's readers ask most, and the only links you should trust for CAT 2026.

Frequently asked questions

I have prepared for only two months. Is 74 days really enough?

Enough for a meaningful, honest improvement - typically not enough to go from zero preparation to a 99th percentile. The realistic arc for a late starter: arithmetic mastery + the DILR two-set discipline + the RC system can carry you several percentile bands above an unstructured peer. Run the plan; let the mocks set the ceiling.

Which section deserves the most hours?

Whichever your diagnostic says is furthest behind your target, weighted by learnability: DILR and arithmetic-heavy QA respond fastest to 74 days of process work; VARC responds steadily to the daily reading habit. Never allocate by fear - allocate by the log.

How many mocks are too many?

Above roughly 15 full mocks in 74 days, analysis quality collapses and fatigue compounds. If you are already at 20+ and scores are swinging, the fix is fewer mocks and deeper analysis, not more mocks.

Should I guess on TITA questions?

Yes - always. TITA carries no negative marking. A narrowed, reasoned guess on every TITA you can touch is free expected value. On MCQs, guess only after eliminating at least two options.

Coaching classes or self-study now?

With 74 days left, structured classroom programmes mostly re-teach the syllabus you should already be past. A test series (for mocks) plus this system is the efficient package. The exception: if a whole section is fundamentally broken, a targeted short module on that section alone can pay.

What percentile do I need?

It depends on the institutions and category you are targeting, and cutoffs move yearly - check each B-school's current admissions page rather than trusting a coaching billboard. Plan to maximize your own delta; targets set by others' numbers are just noise for the next 74 days.

Should I use the on-screen calculator?

Know it, do not need it. It exists on the exam interface (the official mock shows it), but every minute at the calculator is a minute not scanning the next question. Train the whole 74 days on rough paper; treat the calculator as a checksum for one or two heavy computations, not a habit.

Telegram groups, prep forums, daily analysis videos - helpful or harmful?

As signal, occasionally useful; as environment, corrosive. Fix: one information-check per day at a fixed time, from official sources only, and exit every group that argues about cutoffs. Comparison is the fastest route to a bad November.

What if my mock scores plateau at 60-70 percentile through October?

Plateaus are diagnostic events, not verdicts. Open the log and count error types: if concept gaps dominate, repair (the repair loop); if selection and time dominate, the fix is process rules, not more study. If both look clean and scores still stall, the usual culprit is analysis depth - your 3:1 ratio has quietly become 1:0.

Official resources - the only links that matter

- iimcat.ac.in - the sole official CAT 2026 website: registration status, admit card (from Nov 4), the official mock test, and all genuine announcements. The IIMs have warned against every other site claiming affiliation.
- The CAT 2026 information bulletin and registration guide (available on iimcat.ac.in) - the authoritative word on pattern, fees and rules.
- Previous-year papers (2017-2025) through the official CAT website - your highest-value practice material, free.
- xatonline.in - the official XAT 2027 website: registration open until December 6, 2026; exam January 3, 2027.
- Your target B-schools' own admissions pages - the only source whose cutoffs and process actually bind you.

Sources for every exam fact in this playbook

IIM Indore press release for CAT 2026 (July 26, 2026) and the CAT 2026 information bulletin and registration guide - exam date, sessions, duration, section locks, cities, edit window, fees. The official CAT 2025 media release (December 1, 2025) - question counts, centre and candidate statistics, PwD timings. Registration-deadline extension to September 22, 2026, and the November 4 admit-card date, as announced via iimcat.ac.in and reported on September 15-16, 2026. Slot timings and the expected January 2027 result window as reported by established education outlets covering the official announcements. CAT 2025 question-type splits, difficulty commentary and topic distributions from post-exam analyses by major national coaching institutes (all labelled as institute analysis, not official data). XAT 2027 dates and fees from the official XAT website, xatonline.in. Where this book gives advice rather than fact - schedules, tactics, targets - it is clearly framed as method, and your own error log should override it wherever your data disagrees.

CHAPTER A

The One-Page Exam-Day Rule Card

Print this page. Fold it. Put it in your wallet on November 28 and read it in the queue on November 29. Nothing else goes in.

Scan before solving. DILR: 4 minutes, all sets, classify A/B/C before touching anything.

Two sets, done clean. I do not need five sets. I need two perfect ones and picked-off singles.

Two minutes, then move. No question earns a third unrewarded minute. Mark and go.

TITA: always answer. No negative marking. A reasoned guess is free expected value.

MCQ: eliminate two first. If I cannot eliminate two options, I leave it blank.

Read once, answer from the map. I do not re-read passages. My map knows where things live.

QA: scroll first. Find my arithmetic bank in the first 90 seconds and collect it.

Bad section? Contain it. Three breaths, recompute the remaining target, next section starts 0-0.

Eight minutes on a DILR set, maximum. Sunk cost is not a strategy.

Breathe first, then decide. Ten seconds spent calmly saves two minutes spent badly.

The last line

On November 29, I will not be brilliant. I will be boring, systematic and calm - and that is enough.

CHAPTER B

The Math Quick-Reference Sheet

The arithmetic, algebra and geometry results that cover most of what the QA section actually asks. This is a revision aid for the final fortnight - not a substitute for the repair loop.

Percentages and ratios

- Fraction-percent equivalents: $1/6 = 16.67\%$, $1/7 = 14.29\%$, $1/8 = 12.5\%$, $1/9 = 11.11\%$, $1/11 = 9.09\%$, $1/12 = 8.33\%$. Memorise these - they turn multiplication into addition.
- Percentage change: $\text{new/old} = 1 + r/100$. Consecutive changes multiply: $+20\%$ then $-20\% = 1.2 \times 0.8 = 0.96$, i.e. a net 4% loss.
- If $A:B = 3:4$ and $B:C = 5:6$, then $A:B:C = 15:20:24$ - always pass through the common term.
- Successive discounts of $a\%$ and $b\%$ equal a single discount of $a + b - ab/100$ percent.

Averages, mixtures, profit

- Weighted average sits between the two values, positioned in inverse proportion to the weights.
- Alligation: the ratio of quantities = $[\text{average} - \text{other value}] : [\text{average} - \text{own value}]$.
- Profit percent is on cost unless stated otherwise; markup, discount and profit are three different bases.
- Buying x items for the price of y : effective price ratio $x:y$, gain percent = $(y - x)/x \times 100$.

Time, work, speed

- Work: add rates, not times. A (12 days) + B (18 days): rates $1/12 + 1/18 = 5/36$, together $36/5 = 7.2$ days.
- Pipes filling and emptying together: net rate is the algebraic sum (the drain pipe contributes a negative rate).
- Relative speed: same direction subtract, opposite directions add. Trains crossing: time = total length / relative speed.
- Upstream/downstream: boat speed b , stream s ; downstream $b + s$, upstream $b - s$; still-water speed = $(\text{down} + \text{up})/2$.

Numbers

- Divisibility: 3 (digit sum), 4 (last two digits), 8 (last three), 11 (alternating digit sum), and a number is divisible by 2^k or 5^k by looking at exactly k trailing digits.
- Number of factors from prime factorisation: $(\text{power} + 1)$ multiplied across primes.
- $\text{HCF} \times \text{LCM} = \text{product of the two numbers}$. GCD of three numbers divides any integer combination of them.
- Remainders: work modulo the divisor; powers of numbers cycle - find the cycle length before dividing the exponent.

Algebra and geometry

- Identities you must own: $(a+b)^2$, $a^3 \pm b^3$, and $a^n - b^n$ factorising whenever n is anything.

- Inequalities: flipping on multiplication by a negative; square roots only when both sides are non-negative.
- Logarithms: log of a product splits into a sum; change of base for comparisons; log of 1 is 0 and log of the base is 1.
- Triangles: area = $(1/2)ab \sin C$; the triangle inequality; Pythagorean triples (3,4,5), (5,12,13), (8,15,17), (7,24,25).
- Circles: arc and sector proportions; the inscribed angle is half the central angle on the same arc.
- Coordinate basics: distance and section formulas; a line's slope from two points; the midpoint formula.

Modern math

- Arrangements: n distinct objects in a row is $n!$; in a circle is $(n-1)!$.
- Selections with identical items: divide by the factorial of repetition counts.
- At least one: total minus none - complement counting is almost always faster than case counting.
- Two-set Venn: $|A \text{ or } B| = |A| + |B| - |A \text{ and } B|$; extend by symmetry for three sets.

How to use this sheet

Not by reading it. In the final fortnight, cover the right side of each bullet and re-derive the fact from the left side. Facts you cannot re-derive go to the error log for one more repair pass.

74 days. One system. November 29.

Digitalaikart - Premium Digital Products